

Interview Transcription:

Interaction of Local Customer-Shifa with Yashvardhan in Hindi via Gmeet.

Yashvardhan: Hello ma'am, my name is Yashvardhan. I am from IIT Madras, pursuing the Data Science course. For our software group project, we are studying how local logistics businesses operate. I would like to ask you a few questions about your experience. Is that okay?

Shifa (Customer): Yes sir, please go ahead.

Yashvardhan: Before we begin, may I know your name?

Customer: My name is Shifa.

Yashvardhan: Ma'am, what kind of logistics services have you availed till now?

Customer: Sir, we have used logistics services for multiple purposes. For example, during weddings at our home, we have dealt with moving of furniture, decoration materials, and other bulk goods. We also use it for our farming needs—bringing agricultural supplies like seeds and fertilizers, and sending harvested crops to the APMC market. Apart from that, we run a small clothing shop, so we also transport garments through the same local logistics service.

Yashvardhan: How do you usually book the vehicle?

Customer: Sir, I directly call the owner on the phone. But it is very hard to explain exactly how big my crop harvest or furniture is over a phone call. There is no written booking confirmation or receipt while booking, everything is done verbally.

Yashvardhan: How do you decide what size vehicle or how many labourers are required?

Customer: Mostly I decide based on cost. I try to reduce expenses as much as possible. If the goods are less, I request a smaller vehicle because the rent is lower. Even for labour, I try to keep minimum workers to reduce charges. If later we feel it is not enough, then we ask for extra labour or sometimes another vehicle.

Yashvardhan: Has it ever happened that the vehicle was too small for your goods?

Customer: Yes sir, it has happened once or twice. The vehicle turned out to be smaller than required. Because of that, they had to make a second trip. This caused delays and extra costs. It also created inconvenience because the delivery was not completed on time.

Yashvardhan: Once the vehicle is booked, how do you track it?

Customer: There is no tracking system. I don't get any live location or updates. If I want to know where the vehicle is, I call the owner directly. Sometimes he checks with the driver and informs me. But there is no fixed timing or proper tracking facility.

Yashvardhan: Have you experienced delays in delivery?

Customer: Yes sir, especially during harvest season. At that time, there are many orders, and vehicles get busy. Sometimes they arrive late. In farming, timing is very important. If crops are not sent to the market on time, market prices may fall, and we face financial loss.

Yashvardhan: How do you make payments?

Customer: Sometimes I pay the full amount immediately. Sometimes I pay partially — half before the service and the remaining after completion. Since we are farmers, sometimes we pay after selling our crops in the APMC market and receiving money. When funds are available, we clear the payment.

Yashwardhan: Thank you, ma'am, for your time and valuable insights.

Customer: Thank you sir.

Summary:

Yashvardhan interviews Shifa, a local customer who uses rural logistics services for multiple purposes, including wedding-related furniture shifting, transporting agricultural supplies (seeds and fertilizers), sending harvested crops to the APMC market, and moving garments for her clothing shop.

Shifa books services by directly calling the owner, as there is no formal booking system or written confirmation. She finds it difficult to accurately explain the size and quantity of goods over the phone. Decisions regarding vehicle size and number of laborers are mostly based on cost considerations, often leading to underestimation. On some occasions, the assigned vehicle was too small, requiring additional trips, which caused delays and extra expenses.

There is no tracking system available after booking. To check the vehicle's status, she must call the owner, who then contacts the driver. During peak harvest seasons, delays are common due to high demand, which can result in financial losses if crops do not reach the market on time.

Payments are made either fully upfront, partially before and after service, or sometimes later after crops are sold in the APMC market. Overall, her challenges stem from verbal booking, lack of tracking, cost-driven miscalculations and seasonal delays